

Chapter

Know God, Don't Merely Believe — Many Forms of One Truth



Introduction: Why Were We Given Images?

In our homes and temples there are countless pictures and idols of God — Ganapati, Shiva, the Goddess, Vishnu. But why were these forms given to us at all? Acharya Upendra Ji opens this short discourse with a saying of Vedavyasa Ji:

"Vedavyasa Ji himself says — because he too made many such pictures — and in it, it is said: 'sādhakānām hitārthāya brahmaṇo rūpa-kalpanā'."

The saying means: a form of Brahman has been conceived for the benefit of seekers. Acharya Ji explains it in simple words:

"For the benefit of seekers, for attaining the real Paramatma, for understanding Him — because that **formless** one cannot be grasped right away — some **form with shape** has been given to us to understand."

Nirakara — that which has no form; **sakara** — that which has form, which can be seen and worshipped. The form is a ladder, not the destination. So Acharya Ji immediately cautions:

"This much we have understood. But if you drown in that alone, it won't do."

In Love with a Photo: An Example

To make this clear, Acharya Ji gives an example that sounds light-hearted but strikes deep:

"Suppose someone gave you a photo from some random newspaper or from somewhere else — you don't even know that person. You don't know them, don't recognise them, don't know where they live, know nothing. And you straight away say, 'Oh, I have fallen in love with this person!' — how many people would say that?"

He accepts that a picture can attract, but love and marriage are another matter:

"Yes, seeing it in a magazine, one can certainly be attracted, but can one say, 'I have fallen in love'? And 'this is my wife or husband, we are married, it's settled' — and after that he talks to it every day; how would that be?"

"'I love you, I love you not' — doing something like this, won't people think he is mad?"

He also clarifies why he did not use the example of a mother — because we do know our mother. The point here is about someone we **do not know at all**.

The Same Is Happening in Religion

Now Acharya Ji applies the example to religion:

"That is the very form our religion, too, is slowly taking. In place of a photo, we have even been given an idol — think of it as the three dimension of it, like in a wax museum."

"So if you are given something like that, you don't even know it, don't even recognise it, don't know where it lives — and yet, 'I am connected to it, I have fallen in love with you.'"

The idol in itself is not wrong — it was given precisely for the benefit of seekers. The mistake is when we stop at the idol and never try to know the One whose idol it is.

The First Step of Devotion: Love or Self-Interest?

We easily say that our devotion is to Ganapati, or Shiva, or the Goddess. Acharya Ji asks — what lies at the root of that

devotion?

"The first step of bhakti is **love**. And we say, 'My devotion is to Ganapati, or Shiva, or the Goddess.' So was there love before that devotion? If not, then it is **self-interest**."

"A person connects either through love, or else through self-interest. So what has yours been until now? Self-interest — 'O God, give me this' — God gives, does my work, removes obstacles."

And if there truly is love, it carries a natural demand:

"And if there is love, then you must **know** Him; otherwise it is a wrong, **blind-faith** kind of love — knowing nothing. Does a marriage like that happen, with a photo?"

The Message of the Gita: Know, Don't Merely Believe

This is the central thread of the discourse. Acharya Ji says that the Bhagavad Gita and the Ganesh Gita both say the same thing:

"In both the Bhagavad Gita and the Ganesh Gita, the same thing is said: **God is to be known**; it is not said that He is to be merely believed in."

Merely believing means that the form has been imposed on us, and our rishis do not accept that:

"We are believing in Ganesh as having such a form — meaning Ganapati has been imposed on you by someone. Our own rishis say: this doesn't work, this is wrong."

"If you do this, exactly the same thing will happen — marriage with a photo, love with a photo. Who she is, you don't know; where she lives, you don't know. In the same way, where is this God? We have not seen."

Acharya Ji also reminds us that attaining God is a real possibility — someone must have attained Him:

"There must be some real devotee too, who has actually attained Ganesh."

And he makes clear where the example ends:

"I gave this only as an example. Ganapati can belong to thousands; a wife will belong to only one — I am not talking about that, it is just an example."

First, Questions Must Arise

Knowing begins with a question. Acharya Ji says that to reach God, questions must awaken in the mind:

"Know God — it is not said, believe. **Reach Him.** So first a question should arise in your mind: why is it like this? Why the elephant-headed one?"

"A second question should arise: how did there come to be so many forms, when it is said just once — 'sabka malik ek', the Master of all is one — people say that, don't they?"

And then he takes the question further:

"If it is said 'the Master of all is one', then why is Ganapati not there among people of other religions? So is my God limited to my religion?"

"Here even another devotee is saying, 'Yours is separate, ours is separate.'"

The Devotees Who Would Not Say "Shankar"

Acharya Ji tells a true incident showing the narrowness that devotion without knowing creates. At Diwali he visited some acquaintances. Among the festive snacks (**faral**) they served a diamond-shaped sweet known as **shankarpale**:

"And they said to me, 'Here, pale, pale!' What is that? I know what it is — it is called shankarpale. They said, 'Our guru has forbidden us to say "Shankar".' What kind of thing is that? 'We are Vishnu devotees.'"

Acharya Ji's reply is the core vision of our scriptures:

"Arre, Vishnu's beloved deity is Shankar, and Shankar's beloved deity is Vishnu! Ganapati is a form of Vishnu — read his story and you will understand."

Vaishnava, Shakta or Shaiva?

The second incident is even clearer. A seeker invited a friend, saying that here the knowledge of Ganesh and the Bhagavad Gita are taught:

"So he made a decision — meaning, yes, these must be Vaishnava people. Then, after just a few days, he was told, 'Navratri has come, they teach about the Goddess.' Now he was confused — they teach Navratri too, Durga too; that means these are **Shaktas**, not **Vaishnavas**."

"And a few days after that, he was invited for Shivaratri — 'They seem to be **Shaivas**! This can't even be a guru' — that was the conclusion he gave."

Vaishnava — a worshipper of Vishnu; **Shakta** — a worshipper of the Goddess (Shakti); **Shaiva** — a worshipper of Shiva. For that man these were three separate boxes, and a guru who taught all three did not seem "real" to him. But what do the scriptures themselves say?

The Ganesh Gita's Answer: Seeing No Difference Is Yoga

Acharya Ji says the answer is in the very first chapter of the Ganesh Gita, where Shri Ganesh explains what is called yoga:

"In it He Himself writes: I alone am Shiva, I alone am the Goddess, I alone am everything — Vishnu, Rudra, Brahma."

**aham eva mahāviṣṇur aham eva sadāśivaḥ
aham eva mahāśaktir aham evāryamā priya**
"O dear one, I alone am Mahavishnu, I alone am
Sadashiva, I alone am Mahashakti, and I alone am
the Sun."

— Ganesh Gita, Chapter 1

Aryama — a name of the Sun. And then the verse that is the
essence of this whole discourse:

**śive viṣṇau ca śaktau ca sūrye mayi narādhipa
yābheda-buddhir yogaḥ sa samyag-yogo mato
mama**

"O King, the yoga that is an understanding of non-
difference between Shiva, Vishnu, Shakti, the Sun
and Me — Me meaning Ganesh — that alone I
consider true yoga."

— Ganesh Gita, Chapter 1

Abheda-buddhi — the understanding that these forms are
not separate, but forms of the one Paramatma. One who sees

no difference between Shiva, Vishnu, Shakti, the Sun and Ganesh is established in true yoga. The devotees who avoided the word "Shankar", and the seeker who doubted a guru for celebrating all three festivals — both missed this understanding of non-difference.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 The form is a means, not the goal** — "sādhakānām hitārthāya brahmaṇo rūpa-kalpanā": a form has been given to seekers to understand the formless Paramatma; drowning in it and stopping there will not do.
- 2 Love without knowing is like marrying a photo** — to say "I have fallen in love" with someone we do not even know is blind faith.
- 3 The first step of devotion is love** — if "give me this" lies at the root of devotion, it is not love but self-interest.
- 4 God is to be known, not merely believed in** — both the Bhagavad Gita and the Ganesh Gita say this: reach Him.

- 5 **Let questions arise** — why the elephant-headed form?
How so many forms? If the Master of all is one, is my
God limited to my religion?
- 6 **Sectarian walls are built by ignorance** — Vishnu's
beloved deity is Shankar, and Shankar's beloved deity is
Vishnu; boxing people into Vaishnava, Shakta and
Shaiva is not the vision of the scriptures.
- 7 **Seeing no difference is true yoga** — to see no difference
between Shiva, Vishnu, Shakti, the Sun and Ganesh —
this, according to the Ganesh Gita, is true yoga.